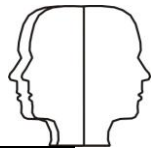
Lesson 10 – Cognitive Self-Change: Thinking Check-in



Summary and Rationale

The 3 steps of cognitive self-change can be practiced in a brief form by using a **thinking check-in.** With a thinking check-in, each group member reports on a situation in which he/she has experienced some degree of risk.

The thinking check-in has 4 parts:

1. Brief report of the situation.
2. Brief report of the thoughts and feelings.
3. Identify the risk in those thoughts and feelings.
4. Find new thinking. Describe the new thinking they used (or could have used, depending on their level of competence) to reduce their risk of doing something hurtful or criminal.

A thinking check-in is a performance of all 3 steps of cognitive self-change. A complete thinking check-in (when new thinking has actually been used) is the complete process of cognitive self-change in miniature. We use the thinking check-in process as part of the homework in future lessons.

Concepts and Definitions

A **thinking check-in** is a brief report of a risk situation and the application of the 3 steps of cognitive self-change to that situation.

Objectives – As a result of this lesson the group members will:

1. Practice a thinking check-in to reinforce the 3 steps of cognitive self-change in his/her everyday life.

2. Continue to develop the skill of objective self-observation.

Major Activities

Activity 1 – Overview

Activity 2 – Group Members Practice Thinking Check-ins with Homework Assignments

Activity 3: Repeat Activity 2 with all Group Members

Activity 3 – Wrap-up

Activity 5- Assign Homework

Supplements

Charts – Make before facilitating lesson. (See supplement section in each lesson for full text of chart page.)

Denoted in lesson plan with this symbol:

Handouts – Make copies before lesson. (See supplement section of each lesson for camera ready pages.)

Denoted in lesson plan with this symbol:

H-10-1-Homework Sheet

Presentation Slides – Make transparencies if projector is not available. (See supplement section of each lesson for camera ready pages.)

Denoted in lesson plan with this symbol:

P-10-1-Lesson Title
P-10-2–Cognitive Self Change
P-10-3-Thinking Check-in
P-10-4-Homework

Equipment	Supplies
▪ Easel (chart stand) ▪ Projector to show presentation slides ▪ Projection screen or suitable surface	▪ Chart paper ▪ Markers ▪ Masking tape ▪ Copies of handouts

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Activity 1 – Overview of Lesson 10

For homework, you were asked to watch for situations when you felt some degree of stress or tension or conflict. These kinds of situations are risky for most of us. They tend to bring out thoughts and feelings that have the potential of leading to trouble.

Would *(group member name)* please review step 1 of cognitive self-change by reading the slide? Thank you.

Would *(group member name)* please review step 2 of cognitive self-change by reading the slide? Thank you.

Would *(group member name)* read step 3 of cognitive self-change? Thank you.

Transition

In a few minutes, you are going to use your homework thinking reports to practice a new way of using the 3 steps of cognitive self-change, called a " thinking check-in."

Thinking Check-in

A thinking check-in is a very brief report that uses all 3 steps of cognitive self-change.

A thinking check-in is an oral report; you don't write the report.

P-10-1

P-10-2

P-10-3

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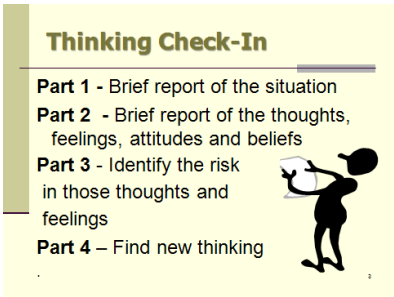
A thinking check-in has 4 parts.	
1. Provide a brief report of the situation. 2. Provide a brief report of the thoughts and feelings, attitudes and beliefs that were happening at the time of the situation.	Explain to group members that this is like the thinking report process that they have practiced many times. In fact, the check-in, like the thinking report also has 4 parts.
3. Identify the risk in those thoughts, feelings, and attitudes and beliefs. Describe how this thinking puts you at risk of breaking a rule or hurting someone.	Explain that "risk" means any degree of risk. The risk in thinking may be very small, but it's still important to notice it.
4. Find new thinking to reduce that risk. Identify some new thinking; a thought or attitude and belief, which you could use in this situation that would reduce your risk to act that way. Your new thinking must still let you feel good about yourself.	Explain to group members that this is a time to practice new ways to think. Don't expect them to identify (in this check-in practice) new thinking that will work for them every time, or for the rest

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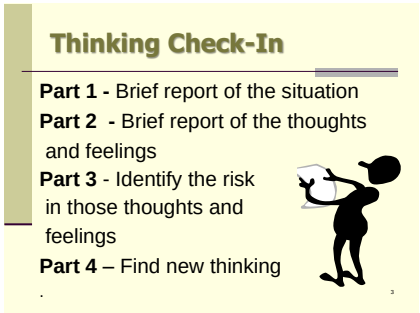
	of their life.
All the parts of a check-in are done quickly. After some practice, you will be able to give check-in's in just a couple of minutes.	
Transition	
Let's get started. We will practice thinking check-in's by using the thinking reports you prepared for homework.	
Activity 2: Group Members Practice Thinking Check-in's with Homework Assignments	
Who would like to start?	P-10-3
1. Start by giving us an objective description of the situation. You've practiced this before. Keep it brief and factual. That's fine. You've done part 1 of a thinking check-in.	
2. Now tell us about the thoughts, feelings, and attitudes and beliefs you were having at the time of the situation. You can read them right off of your thinking report. There you go. That is part 2 of a thinking check-in. Not so hard, is it?	Display the slide of the thinking check-in parts. Point to each part as you guide the group member. With more practice, group members will speak their thinking reports without

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	reading them, but to begin, it's easier to read them. This was part of the homework assignment, so the group member should be prepared. But be prepared to coach the group member if necessary.
3. Now, tell us how your thinking, feelings, and attitudes and beliefs put you at risk. That risk could be breaking a rule, or hurting someone, including yourself, or doing something you might later regret.	Any plausible explanation of risk (i.e., of how the thinking pointed the group member toward a hurtful behavior) is acceptable—provided it shows that the group member is truly reflecting on his/her thinking and on how that thinking can lead them to hurtful behavior. Be prepared to explain the idea of risk again, in terms of this group member's specific situation and the specific hurtful behavior they

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	were at risk of doing.
4. Good. Now let's do the part that was not assigned as homework. What new thinking could you have used in this situation to reduce your risk?	
Group members, do you have any ideas for new thoughts or attitudes or beliefs that (*reporting group member*) could have used to reduce his/her risk?	The reporting group member is always the final authority.
What do you think, (reporting group member)), would any of those thoughts have worked for you?	
Would you like to add any additional new thoughts of your own?	Keep this process brief and simple.
Now, most importantly, can you see how thinking these new thoughts might lead you to acting in a different way?	Always remember to connect thinking to behavior. The primary objective at this point is to show how easy thinking check-in's are – not to squeeze as much out of them as we can. Remember, a check-in is intended to be quick practice. Nothing should be written down.

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Great job! Who wants to go next?	
Activity 3: Repeat Activity 2 with All Group Members	
Okay (group member name), part 1 of a thinking check-in is to give a brief, factual report of the situation…	Continue until every group member has presented a thinking check-in based on the thinking report from their homework. This could be a relatively short lesson. If there is time left, consider doing one of the following: **Option #1:** Continue with more thinking check-in's with group members thinking of brand new situations. Have them report from memory without writing them down and reading them. Or **Option #2:** Ask individual group members to take turns facilitating a thinking check-in from

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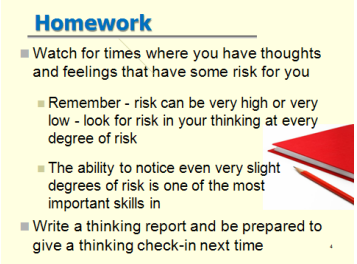
	other group members. Have them refer to the thinking check-in slide as a guide. Coach the group member in the role of facilitator, not the group member presenting the check-in.
Activity 4: Wrap-Up Good job! You have learned how to do all 3 steps of cognitive self-change. With more practice you will be able to identify the risk in your thinking and make changes in that thinking right on the spot – even while the situation is actually going on. In the next lesson we will return to learning about social skills. Remember, social skills teach you a series of simple steps for dealing with a whole lot of different kinds of social situations. These social skills teach you specific ways to put new thinking into practice. You'll continue to practice using the thinking check-in as part of the social skills lessons.	
Activity 5: Assign Homework • Between now and the next session watch	Completing the homework assignment is critical. It is an opportunity for

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for times where you have thoughts and feelings that have some risk for you. o Remember that risk can be very high or very low. o The ability to notice even very slight degrees of risk in your thinking is one of the most important skills in **Thinking for a Change**. • Complete a thinking report form and be prepared to give a thinking check-in on this situation at the beginning of the next lesson.	each group member to transfer the skills he/she has practiced in the session to real life situations. As he/she completes the homework, the new skills begin to integrate into his/her thoughts, feelings, attitudes and beliefs, and behavior. H-10-1-Homework Handout P-10-4